Modernist Period

1880-1940

Introduction

The modernism design period ranged from the 1880's until the 1940's . Modernism overlapped the periods of world war one, world war two and the cold war and was largely influenced by the emergence of technology.[1] At the same time, the second industrial revolution guided the emergence of many important technologies, such as the invention of the first car, the zipper and the television.[2]

This was not without challenges as the Great Economic Depression and the Spanish Influenza Epidemic slumped technological growth.[3] Through the innovation of many technologies and objects, Modernism largely influenced the economic and social environment that we live in today.[4] Modernism as a style of design was focused largely on the idea of functionality and moved away from embellishment styles such as those of Art Nouveau and Art Deco that occurred during the same time period.[5]

More closely related to Modernism, Bauhaus emerged, as did Futurism, which celebrated pleasure, change, and destruction of moralism in culture and society.[6]
The essence of Modernism can be seen through an analysis of the following prominent designers; Pablo Picasso, Ludwig Mies van der Rohe, Frank Lloyd Wright and Charles Edouard Jeanneret, as well as a range of designs from that era such as the Egg Chair, the modern drinking straw, the Bauhaus building and the Jerry Can.

Impact

Modernism has largely impacted many of the design products and social structures existing and emerging today, and it is no wonder that the term modernism is so widely used.

As an iconic pillar of Modernism in architecture, Bauhaus continues to inspire architectural history for both its form and function. Furthermore, the design philosophies of both Frank Lloyd Wright's and Le Corbiur pushed the boundaries of architectural design, and continue to be harnessed within new architecture that forms our growing societies.
As does the legacy of Pablo Picasso, who fosters familiarity and remains a historical and revolutionary guide to the foundations of art.

Reflective of the growing demand for domestic practices in this era, modernism saw the development of many products that have significantly contributed to the convenience of everyday life. The modern drinking straw and the egg chair imagined during modernism have both continued to improve and adapt through generations. Whilst furthermore, the timeless Jerry Can has remained consistent in design for over eighty years. These products all represent modernism's goal of functionality and make outstanding contributions to society and improved living standards in the twenty-first century. If it were not for modernism, the world today would be far less functional.

1880

Modern Drinking straw
1888

Straws are commonly accepted nowadays. People can use them to conveniently drink beverages. In the 1800s, Marvin Stone invented paper straws by wrapping paper around a pencil.[7] Before that, straws were made of natural ryegrass, which could disintegrate into the liquid and leave a grassy flavour.[8]

The invention of straws has both positive and negative impacts. Straws are necessary for people who have trouble swallowing or lifting a cup.[9] Straws may also benefit people's dental health because they can limit the contact between teeth and the fluid.[10] However, plastic straws gradually took over paper straws in the 1900s, which caused significant environmental problems, especially for oceans and coasts.[11] The extreme overuse of plastic straws has further aggravated the habitat destruction of birds and aquatic species.[12] Therefore, a lot of countries have banned the usage of plastic straws.

Frank Lloyd Wright
1867 - 1959

Frank Lloyd Wright was a designer and architect from the US. He designed thousands of structures over 70 years.[13] His 'Prairie House' and 'Usonian House' influenced young designers around the world.[14] The design philosophies he believed in were Design for Democracy, Integrity and Connection, as well as Nature's structures and Material.[15]

Wright was one of the greatest designers in the era of Modernism. He has unique design ideology and methodology, these were fully presented in his Lewis's Richardson House.[16] He not only supported the US to find its architectural identity but also promoted an approach of linking the surroundings with architectural designs.[16] His design deeply impacted the houses we live in today and presaged sustainability concerns.[17] Moreover, research has shown that Wright's designs (fewer walls in buildings and more opportunities to see nature) can shorten hospital stays and allow people to have more interactions and activities.[18]

Bauhaus
1919

Bauhaus, meaning 'building house' was designed by the iconic Modernist architect Walter Gropius in Dessau, Germany.[20] It is a classic expression of modernist style and was built for and functioned as a school of arts with a primary focus on architecture, applied arts and design. Bauhaus was forced to close due to Nazi rule in the second world war.[21]

Built with asymmetrical balance and the use of industrial materials, the building was a visual novelty of its time. Fitted with functional equipment and different shapes, the layout of Bauhaus favours function over form and is a perfectly coherent representation of Modernism within architecture.[22] The Bauhaus building was not only a perfectly structured architectural representation of Modernism, but it remains historically emblematic as a school that both taught, influenced and housed students of Modernism.[23] Therefore, fully encompassing the era of Modernism and transforming into a historical landmark.

Pablo Picasso
1881 - 1973

Pablo Picasso is the originator of modernism and one of the representatives of western modernist painting.[1] He was a famous painter and sculptor born in Spain and has created 37,000 masterworks in his lifetime, involving many art fields. Furthermore, his works not only alone excel in modernism, but also enjoy a high reputation in many other artistic schools.

Pablo Picasso is still forever changing the art of the world. He is the founder of modernism which completely transformed the art circle in the 20th century. He was covered with personal honors and achieved the most creations of painting in the world, which has been recognized by Guinness World Records,[2] thus his works subsequently have been most stolen. Female themes linger in the works, creating and crossing his 5 distinguished periods. He also had a large collection of art masterpieces from his generations, and there are 3 world-famous museums especially established for him in France and Spain. Meanwhile his works have also been successfully spread to many museums globally.

Ludwig Mies van der Rohe
1886 - 1969

Ludwig Mies van der Rohe was German architect who is considered one of the first modernist architects. Mies' himself summed up his personal style of architecture with the phrases "less is more" and "God is in the details".[3] While his physical works were limited until he moved to America in the late 1930's, his many sketched works show his dedication to and the influence of his style.

Mies' style encompassed the key principles of modernist architecture. "He is the only modern architect who formulated a genuinely contemporary and universally applicable architectural canon, and office buildings all over the world echo his concepts".[4] His early sketches of large Skyscrapers essentially set the stage for modern architecture; and his heavy use of glass and steel still dominates global architectural designs to this day.[5] As well as his limited use of non-functional features/decorations. His emphasis on the need for efficiency and functionality in architecture can be seen as a prelude to modern-day requirements for the use of sustainable resources and energy efficiency.

Le Corbusier
1887 - 1965

Le Corbusier was a Swiss architect, theorist and painter who performed influential work in city planning, and public and private housing. The work of whom was largely reflective of Modernism as a style and aided [illegible] him is becoming a pioneer in the movement.

Le Corbusier's quote "The house is a machine for living"[1] represents his embodiment of Modernism as a way of life as well as a style of design. His work in large-scale private housing has become influential in redefining the idea of living as we experience it today.[2] The 'Five Points of Architecture' as theorised by Le Corbusier are design principles that have been used throughout history. Not only are they used as the foundation for many designs and designers, but they stimulateneously assist in keeping core elements of modernism present in society today.[3]

Jerry Can
1937

The Wehrmacht-Einheitskanister, or Jerry Can, was a fuel storage/transport product initially developed for the German military and quickly adopted/stolen/copied by the British and American militaries in the late 1930's.[4] It is a product of purely functional design that addresses most if not every practical concern with the storage and transportation of fuel.

Now, nearly eighty years after its original creation, the jerry can is a product with universal recognition and everyday usage with little to no changes to its original design. In Australia, for example, jerry cans are still one of the only legal means of getting fuel from a petrol station.[5] Former US president Franklin D. Roosevelt credited the Jerry Can for the Allies' quick victory in Europe, saying that: "Without these cans it would have been impossible for our armies to cut their way across France at a lightning pace which exceeded the German Blitz of 1940".[6]

Egg Chair
1953

1960

The Egg Chair has become a most iconic modernism masterpiece that broke through the traditional conventions with a strong modernism consciousnesses. Its prototype was designed and manufactured by hand by Arne Jacobsen in his Copenhagen garage,[1] and based on ergonomics to relieve the pain of the shoulder, back and waist in supporting the body posture, inspired by the eggs hatched.

The Egg Chair is not only a masterpiece in ergonomics, but leads the modernism climax. The primitive Egg Chair was hand-made with top-of-the-line fabrics to ensure the elasticity, in the case of human comfort, while achieving the design concept of durability without deformation in that era of immature machines. It comes with a 360-degree rotation and tilt function, which is why it is relatively user-orientated. At present, its figure has been popularized to countless places throughout the world, and afterwards numerous reproductions and modifications based on and imitated it as the predecessor. The Egg Chair has been deserved to be the most multifunctional, fashionable and influential series around the world.[2]

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